



7 Rikki-Tikki-Tavi

Rikki-tikki was a mongoose. His eyes and the end of his nose were pink. He could scratch himself anywhere he pleased with any leg, back or front, and he could fluff up his tail until it looked like a bottle brush. His war cry as he scuttled through the long grass was: rikk-tikk-tikki-tikki-tchk!

One day, a summer flood washed him out of the burrow where he lived and carried him down a roadside ditch. He found a little wisp of grass floating there and clung to it till he lost his senses.

When he revived, he was lying in the hot sun in the middle of a garden path. A small boy and his mother took him into the house and a big man picked him up between his finger and thumb and said that he was not dead. So they wrapped him in cotton wool and warmed him over a little fire, and he opened his eyes and sneezed.

It is the hardest thing in the world to frighten a mongoose, because he is full of curiosity.

They gave him a little piece of raw meat. Rikki-tikki liked it immensely, and when it was finished, he went out into the veranda and sat in the sunshine and fluffed up his fur to make it dry to the roots. Then he felt better. He spent all that day roaming all over the house. And when Teddy, the small boy, went to bed, Rikki-tikki climbed



up, too. Teddy's mother and father came in to look at their son and saw Rikki-tikki on the pillow.

'I don't like that,' said Teddy's mother. 'He may bite the child.'

'He'll do no such thing,' said the boy's father.

'Teddy is safer with that little beast than if he had a bloodhound to watch over him.'

(Adapted from *Rikki-Tikki-Tavi* by Rudyard Kipling)



A Match each **word** with the **meaning** it has in the passage:

1. fluff	(a) walking around without any definite aim
2. scuttled	(b) a small, thin piece of something
3. burrow	(c) an open space, with a roof, on the side of a house
4. ditch	(d) a strong desire to know or learn
5. wisp	(e) to shake something to make it look larger
6. revived	(f) a large dog with a very good sense of smell
7. curiosity	(g) a hole made in the ground and used as a shelter by some animals
8. veranda	(h) regained consciousness
9. roaming	(i) ran with quick, short steps
10. bloodhound	(j) a long, narrow channel dug at the edge of a field or road, etc. to carry water away

B Answer the following questions:

1. Who was Rikki-tikki-tavi? Describe him.
2. How do you think Rikki-tikki got his name?
3. Where did the summer flood carry Rikki-tikki?
4. How was he treated by the family which found him?
5. Why is it hard to frighten a mongoose?
6. What did Rikki-tikki eat and how did he dry himself completely?
7. What did Teddy's mother fear?
8. What did Teddy's father think?

C Say which of the **underlined verbs** are **transitive** and which **intransitive**. Point out the **objects** of the transitive verbs.

1. He could fluff up his tail until it looked like a bottle brush.
2. He lost his senses.
3. He was not dead.
4. They wrapped him in cotton wool.
5. They gave him raw meat.
6. He spent the day roaming all over the house.
7. They saw Rikki-tikki on the pillow.

D Pick out the **adjectives** and **adverbs** from the following sentences and say of what kind each is. Also mention which **word** each adjective or adverb qualifies.

1. He scuttled through the long grass.
2. Rikki-tikki liked it immensely.
3. It is the hardest thing in the world to frighten a mongoose.
4. Rikki-tikki climbed up.
5. 'He'll do no such thing,' said the boy's father.

E Pick out a **reflexive pronoun** from the passage. Point out the **verb** it is the **object** of and the **subject** of that verb.

F Write an essay on how curiosity once got you into trouble. Give your essay a title.

